Father, a character from the game Smite, using EVA foam, fabrics and 3D printed technology to create it. Part of a family-run manufacturing business, Shaikh's innate skill in arts and crafts is fulfilled with cosplay, a portmanteau word of 'costume play', where he gets to make ingenious and imaginative costumes from scratch. By his own estimate, he has made 15 since he started in 2018. "It was a great opportunity to showcase my passion," says Shaikh. "To be in the presence of so many stars was overwhelming. I was like 'what the hell is happening!' My family was shocked that I went on such a big stage. It was a big moment for me."

Categories like cosplay, anime, manga and EDM (electronic dance music) demonstrated that the ministry was courting young India's niche interests that trace their origins to countries abroad. Srikanth Vemula was happy that EDM was given a spotlight at the forum. Son of an IFS officer and a doctor, Vemula was drawn to EDM for the intensity and impact of its sound. The Hyderabad-born, Mumbai-based music producer and DJ prepared a track—'With You'—which won gold at Resonate: The EDM Challenge. Nearly three months in the making, the thus far unreleased track, a criterion for the challenge, shows Vemula's penchant to create uplifting melodies. "My music includes blending electronic sounds with Indian instruments like tabla and sitar to bring a different experience of music that my audience relates to," Vemula said. "With WAVES, you get to show what's so unique in your creation." Vemula hopes the win can help his larger pursuit—to headline big music festivals and make good music behind the console.

Women's participation notably high in the Animation Challenge, with finalists from Bali, Nigeria and the United Kingdom, and at least six female filmmakers bagging trophies. Among the brightest Indian stars was Shreeyaa Pore, whose animated short *Kali* (translated as *A Flower Bud* in Marathi), on the ostracism that young girls face during menstruation and the many taboos around it, won the best animated film category. A 21-year-old aspiring animation filmmaker from Pune, Pore submitted an animatics version—a rough cut with action, sound and background visuals—of her just-completed graduation short. "I wanted more people to see it and for it to be shown on a big platform like WAVES," she says. For Pore, the summit offered an enriching experience and much-needed exposure about the entertainment industry as she embarks on her professional journey. "Connecting with animators from ASIFA (Association International du Film d'Animation) and NID (National Institute of Design) was amazing and hearing their views helped me see my work from a new perspective," she says. "There were so many passionate creators from different backgrounds, it was wonderful seeing all of us on one platform." Pore now awaits her college, Unitedworld Institute of Design's assessment on *Kali*. Regardless of it, she knows she has a winner up her sleeve.

It is a feeling the scores of creative souls who made it to Mumbai came back with. The Create in India Challenge at WAVES gave wings to their dreams. ■



"IT WAS A SPECIAL EXPERIENCE. I TOLD AAMIR [KHAN] SIR THAT IN THE NEXT 5-10 YEARS, WE WILL DO A FILM TOGETHER"

KUSHAGRA TIWARI

Winner, Reel Making–Travel India Challenge

"I BLEND ELECTRONIC SOUNDS WITH INDIAN INSTRUMENTS LIKE SITAR TO BRING A DIFFERENT VIBE. AT WAVES, YOU GET TO SHOW WHAT'S SPECIAL IN YOUR CREATION"

SRIKANTH VEMULA

Winner of Resonate: The EDM Challenge

